

JUST DIVX IT

Convert your DVDs to DivX format and preserve your favourite movies in top-notch condition forever

DVDs, though excellent for playback and storage, are not exactly infallible by nature. They meet with accidents, get scratched, and the chances of you damaging your favourite DVD are as high as all those CDs that you've already damaged. A back up is a back up, always important, so wouldn't it be better if you had a safe place to store that gigantic movie collection you've been busy hoarding?

Well, you do have a place, a format, that's not as large and is of high quality—the DivX format. This will give you a backup file that is of very good quality, is not too big and more importantly, easily stored and played.

Necessary ingredients

Encoding a DVD to DivX involves major processing power and loads of free hard disk space. You can forget about any conversions unless you have a processor of 1 GHz or more and a big hard disk (anything above 40 GB). At least 256 MB of RAM would be nice, although you can get by with 128 MB, but no compromises on the processing power and hard disk space. Encoding takes up almost 100 per cent of a processor's capability.

Our test bench was a Pentium-III running at 1.12 GHz with 256 MB RAM and a 20 GB hard disk. On this bench, it took around 2 hours and 26 minutes to convert a 112-minute DVD into DivX (DivX 4 constant bit rate) using the default resolution and settings. The same movie took around 5 hours and 22 minutes to convert on DivX 4 2-pass. EasyDivX was the only application running on the PC during the conversion process! We didn't try the

DivX 3.11 VKI encoding option due to legal issues.

Now for the things you need to install on the PC other than the conversion software. First of all, you need to have a good software DVD player like PowerDVD. You will need to have the DivX Codecs (DivX 4.12 and DivX 3.11 VKI) installed as well. Windows Media Player is yet another essential tool for playing back the output file.

DivX-encoded movies

are **half the size of MPEG-1** and give **twice as good quality**

DivX-ing those DVDs

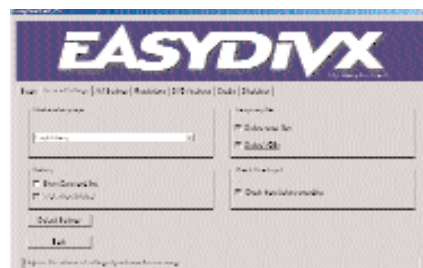
The software we will be using for converting DVD to DivX is EasyDivX. You can get hold of EasyDivX v0.792 (a 1.93 MB download) from <http://easydivx.does.it>. A link for downloading DivX 4.12 is also present on the same page. It is perfectly legal to use EasyDivX if you are only making a single backup of your own DVD. (*Have a look at the box, 'DVD conversion essentials' to get the DVD to DivX conversion basics right*)

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Get, set, DivX

Time to start the encoding process. Play the DVD using PowerDVD. In order to start EasyDivX, click on the Advanced tab and then again on the General Settings tab. Here, click on AVI Settings.

Check the 'Delete temporary files' and 'Delete VOBs' options to delete the



Save space; get rid of temporary files and VOBs

What is DivX?

DivX is a Codec that helps you compress those big media files into a very small size. For example, while converting your DVD into DivX, you will be able to convert the MPEG-2 video and audio files to about one-eighth their size or less (an approximate measure). If you have a DVD that runs to about 7.5 GB, you will be able to convert it to DivX to fit onto a CD of 650 or 700 MB. Of course, the quality won't be as good as that of DVD, but the picture is still pretty good—much better than the other formats around. You will be able to get quality ranging from the kind used for streaming over the Net to near-DVD quality. The most common form of the DivX file is .avi.

Technically speaking, DivX is a digital video compression format (called a Codec), which is based on the MPEG-4 standard from DivX networks. There are two versions of DivX around. One is the original version of DivX, which has versions in the form DivX 3.xx. For example, DivX 3.11 is the original format. This format is basically a hacked version of Microsoft's MPEG-4 v3 Codec, since MPEG-4 v3 did not allow encoding into the .avi format.

The other and newer DivX version is DivX 4.xx. Project Mayo, an open source initiative, developed this format from scratch. The latest member in the 4.xx family is DivX 4.12. We have used this Codec in our workshop. Please note that versions 3.xx and 4.xx are not compatible with each other.

You can download the DivX Player and the DivX Codec 4.12 from www.divx.com or directly from www.download.com.